controversial, Washington has too often failed to articulate the reasons behind such goals—namely, that all nations benefit from an open system that respects national sovereignty, upholds international law, peacefully resolves disputes, and seeks cooperation rather than confrontation. American strategy should not be to try and get states to surrender their own interests, but rather to create mechanisms, relationships, and patterns of behavior that attempt to harmonize transnational goals. Yet it is also clear that avoiding all risk only leads to a deterioration in security. Acting when necessary to maintain stability is thus the best way to avoid greater danger later on. A strategy guided by clear principles and prudently taking advantage of American strengths and partner self-interest is the surest route to keeping the world's most dynamic region open and pacific.

Notes

1. This is the argument of Tyler Dennett, *Americans in Eastern Asia: A Critical Study of United States' Policy in the Far East in the Nineteenth Century* (New York: MacMillan, 1922), especially for much of the nineteenth century, but the argument can be carried forward to the mid-twentieth century without much alteration.
2. US Pacific Command, established in 1947, was renamed US Indo-Pacific Command in May 2018. For use of the term Indo-Pacific as an organizing principle, see Michael R. Auslin, *The End of the Asian Century: War, Stagnation, and the Risks to the World's Most Dynamic Region* (New Haven, CT: Yale University Press, 2017).
3. Marcus Hand, "Malacca and S'pore Straits Traffic Hits New High in 2016, VLCCs Fastest Growing Segment," *Seatrade Maritime News*, February 13, 2017, http://www.seatrade-maritime.com/news/asia/malacca-and-s-pore-strait-traffic-hits-new-high-in-2016-vlccs-fastest-growing-segment.html.
4. Demographic figures are from the US Census Bureau, https://www.census.gov/quickfacts/fact/table/US/PST045216.
5. Trade figures are from the US Census Bureau, https://www.census.gov/foreign-trade/balance/c0016.html.